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HUMANISING SUSTAINABILITY

THERE IS A NEED TO MOVE BEYOND INDIVIDUAL WELL-BEING AND FOSTER A SENSE OF INTERCONNECTEDNESS AND SOLIDARITY

THE CONCEPT OF sustainability has undergone a remarkable evolution in the last 50 years. What started as a niche idea has now matured into a global imperative affecting every aspect of human life. A pivotal moment was the Brundtland Commission Report in 1987, which helped mainstream the idea of sustainable development. In the early 2000s, environmental, social, and governance (ESG) and CSR gained popularity and today, sustainability has transitioned from its green origins to embracing a more human-centric approach that recognises the interplay between social, economic, and environmental dimensions.

India stands at the forefront of this paradigm shift. Its commitment to sustainable development is evident through its ambitious climate policies and targets, and India Inc.'s push for adopting sustainable practices. The government is focussing on various levers like renewables, EVs, green hydrogen, material circularity, etc. to realise its ambitious goals.

One notable initiative is Mission

LiFE launched at COP26—an India-led movement transforming individuals into “pro-planet people”. Additionally, government initiatives like the Swachh Bharat Mission and the Ujjwala Scheme ensure sustainability efforts are inclusive.

Indian companies are increasingly realising the importance of ESG in driving long-term value creation and are adopting sustainable practices to minimise their environmental footprint. Per data, India is leading the emerging economies, with around 79 Indian companies committed to the Science-Based Targets Initiative. Additionally, the introduction of frameworks like the Business Responsibility and Sustainability Report (BRSR), along with Sebi's mandate on BRSR reporting for the top 1,000 listed companies are noteworthy developments.

However, despite the progress, a huge gap remains between the organisations' sustainability intentions and their execution capabilities. A PwC report from April 2024 reveals a mere 31% of companies are disclosing their net-zero targets and only 51% of companies are disclosing their Scope 3 data in India, which serves as a reminder of the gap between the commitments and reality—showcasing how corporates are failing to humanise sustainability.

This highlights the urgent need for a mindset shift—moving away from token gestures to genuine transformation. Sustainability needs to move beyond the boardrooms of corporations or corridors of government to the individual level, where it becomes ingrained in people's consciousness.

Making human-centric sustain-

**Growth should not come
at the cost of people's rights,
health, and quality of life.
It is about having a more
equitable society**